Trinity's dining hall, sharpening their rhetorical skills at Cambridge Majlis, a debating club for Indian students, or listening to the speeches of Indian freedom fighters on their visits to London. Yet, it took almost three decades for their first real intellectual encounter to happen.

In the summer of 1935, Nehru and Iqbal debated over the constitutional exclusion of Ahmadis, a fringe Messianic sect founded by Mirza Ghulam Ahmad in the 1890s in a remote village in Punjab called Qadian.[16] Mirza Ghulam Ahmad saw his mission in cleansing Islam and preparing it for the modern age. Judging purely by his outward ritualistic behaviour, he seemed to follow his puritanical vision faithfully. However, troubles ensued over his eclectic theological claims. Mirza Ghulam Ahmad claimed that he was the reincarnation of Jesus and an avatar of Vishnu, a claim that upset many orthodox scholars.

Around the turn of the century, until he died in 1908, his movement, the Ahmadiyya of Qadian, grew considerably in size when north India was repeatedly hit by the plague. Hard-pressed for options to survive the ravaging black death, thousands of Muslims adopted Mirza as their saviour. He promised that none of his followers would fall victim to the plague. He also asserted that God spoke to him directly and that He had asked him to take on the mantle of a *zilli* (shadowy) prophet. This unique relationship with God, Mirza claimed, gave him glimpses into the near future that often entailed prophecies about the sudden death of his opponents.[17]

In his youth, Iqbal was mighty impressed with the boldness of such overtly prophetic claims. He even called Mirza Ghulam Ahmad 'the profound theologian among modern Indian Muhammadans' in his earliest scholarly writings.[18] Towards the mid-1930s, his views on the Ahmadiyya community had cooled considerably. Where Iqbal had once invited the members of the Ahmadiyya community to participate in the political struggle for securing the constitutional rights of Kashmiri Muslims, he now abandoned the very organization he had helped set up for this cause, with the argument that Ahmadi influence had turned it into an 'an instrument of a specific [Ahmadiyya] propaganda even though it seeks to cover itself with a